2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Emily Alvarez

Grade / Grado 10th

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna Alvaro Alvarez

School / Escuela De La Salle

Email 286020@student.dls.org Phone / Teléfono 224-248-2480

Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

Having a father figure in my life is essential to me. Having a father figure means having someone who will guide and support me to accomplish my goals and dreams in life. My dad is the perfect example of what it means to be a father. He is constantly supporting me and pushing me to be my best self. My dad is one of the most important people in my life. He works hard every day for me and my sisters to be able to provide for us. Although he may not know his work never goes unnoticed, him going to work every day for more than 10 hours a day and still being the best dad he could be is one of the best things I could ask for. Although he may be tired, he never fails to show up. Even through long days he still manages to stand up as a father and do what he is called to do. Never once have I ever questioned the love he has for me. Yes, we might argue a bit, but at the end of the day, everyone does. He always knows how to put a smile on my face when I'm down. He's also one of my biggest supporters, he guides me through life and stays by my side through it all. He pushes me to be my best self as a student, athlete, and as a person in general. As the biggest role model in life, he has paved a path for me to follow. He has taught me how to maintain perseverance and to never settle for anything less because I am worth so much. Having my dad in my life allows me to feel supported, loved, cared for, and overall protected. Knowing I always have someone in my corner to turn to when I need advice, to look for when I need to smile, and to be there no matter what my future holds is the best thing I could ask for in a father. This is what a father means to me.

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

When I showed this to my dad he loved it. Although, my dad isn't a very emotional person but he even began to tear up. He told me how loved he felt and thanked me for just being who I am but I told him I was just stating the truth and then he hugged me.

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

   1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.